



BUILDING A STORYBRAND

Clarify Your Message So Customers Will Listen

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The Big “So What”



Marketing campaigns are often a waste of money because of ineffective messages. **This book presents a 7-part framework to help you present a clear, effective message that'd get your customers' attention and grow your business.** It can be used for any industry or size of business.

Introduction



 To win over your potential customers, you must first understand how they think. All human beings are fundamentally driven by our primitive survival instincts.

- We're constantly scanning the environment for things that can help us to survive and flourish; and
- We try to do this with the least amount of energy/effort.

 Most brands make 2 key mistakes in their marketing campaigns:

- They focus on their brand/company instead of how they can help the customers to survive/thrive.
- The message is too complex. If your message can't be understood in 5 seconds, it's not simple and repeatable enough.

 Stories are powerful because they combine seemingly-disconnected parts/events into a coherent whole, and are thus easy to follow and remember. The StoryBrand framework is a proven formula for storytelling and communication.

- The key to a great message is clarity. To achieve clarity, you must eliminate noise, i.e. cut out irrelevant information that creates clutter and confusion.

KEY QUOTES

“Whether we’re writing a story or attempting to sell products, our message must be clear. Always.”

“What we think we are saying to our customers and what our customers actually hear are two different things.”

“People don’t buy the best products; they buy the products they can understand the fastest.”

“The key to great writing isn’t in what they say; it’s in what they don’t say.”

- This framework uses 7 plot points to filter out noise and present a clear, compelling message. It's like having 7 musical chords that can be combined to create an infinite number of musical pieces. In fact, if you examine any blockbuster movie—from Hunger Games to Star Wars—you'll see the same formula at work.
- Your message must be so clear and simple that it passes the “grunt test”, i.e. even a caveman can instantly grasp it and grunt out the message. When this message is repeated over and over, it crystallizes what your brand stands for and where it fits in your customers’ story.

 Here are the 7 plot points in a nutshell: **A Character (who wants something) has a Problem that he/she is struggling with. A Guide enters the picture, gives a Plan and calls the character to Action. As a result, the character manages to avoid Failure and attain Success.**



 In the next section, we'll zoom in on the details for each of these 7 elements. You can create your 1-page BrandScript for free at mystorybrand.com.

- Miller recommends that you read up on each element, then pause to brainstorm potential options before filtering down to 1 message per section.
- Start by creating the BrandScript for your overall brand, then move into the BrandScript for each of your divisions or even specific products and customer segments.

My StoryBrand BrandScript

A CHARACTER
WHAT DOES HE/SHE WANT?

HAS A PROBLEM
VILLAIN
EXTERNAL
INTERNAL
PHILOSOPHICAL

AND MEETS A GUIDE
EMPATHY
AUTHORITY

WHO GIVES A PLAN
PROCESS
AGREEMENT

AND CALLS THEM TO ACTION
DIRECT
TRANSITIONAL

THAT AVOID FAILURE
TRAGIC OUTCOMES

AND END IN SUCCESS
SUCCESSFUL OUTCOMES

CHARACTER TRANSFORMATION
FROM
TO

KEY QUOTES

“If we want to connect with customers, we have to stop blasting them with noise.”



1. The Character



Your customer is the hero of the story, not your brand.



Your first step is to define who your customer is and what he/she wants in relation to your brand.

- Think of your customers as hitchhikers: they won't hop onboard unless you can take them where they want to go.
- Our brains naturally seek closure. When you show something your customers want, you open a "story gap". They'll want to find out if you can bridge the gap between where they are and where they want to be. Will the underdog win the game? Can the hero save the town? However, if you fail to identify a relevant need, you won't open a story gap.



Focus on 1 thing that helps your customers to survive or thrive.

- No matter how many benefits you offer, force yourself to narrow down to 1 core desire. Have a clear main-plot rather than confuse the audience with too many sub-plots.
- Survival refers to our desire to be safe, healthy, strong and happy. We want to thrive physically, emotionally, relationally, and spiritually, e.g. to enjoy a luxurious and restful holiday, have a secure retirement plan, leave a meaningful legacy, own our dream home, or have a healthy start to each day. You can explore several areas including:
 - (i) *Conserving resources* (e.g. saving time, money, energy) or *accumulating resources* (e.g. making more money, improving productivity);
 - (ii) *Building social networks* for security, connection and support;
 - (iii) *Gaining social status* which is associated with power, prestige and abundance; and

KEY QUOTES

"The customer is the hero, not your brand."

"Customers don't generally care about your story; they care about their own."

(iv) *Providing a sense of meaning and contribution*, e.g. to be a part of something greater than ourselves, or to help others to survive/thrive.

- Keep the message clear and simple. For example, helping your customer to “become everyone’s favorite leader” clearly conveys a range of benefits including respect, success and connections.

2. The Problem



Offer a solution that addresses your customers’ problems at 3 levels.



Now that you’ve entered your customers’ story, you must deepen their interest by identifying a problem they face, e.g. worries about retirement, no time to clean up a messy house. This acts as a “hook” to draw them deeper into the story.



Every good story has a villain that disrupts the hero’s life and creates frustrations. This evil villain now stands between your customers and their desires. The more you talk about the villain, the more your customers want a tool to defeat it. A villain can be anything from distractions to dust mites, so long as it has 4 characteristics:

- It’s a root cause, e.g. an unstable economy causing financial fears;
- It’s relatable, i.e. the customer instantly recognizes and dislikes it;
- It’s singular, i.e. there’s only 1 villain; and
- It’s real.



Zoom in on 3 levels of problems created by this villain:

- External. This is the obvious obstacle between the hero and his/her prize. In movies, this could be a deadly virus or a ticking bomb. In business, this could be a flabby tummy or a leaky roof.
- Internal problems are the underlying causes of external problems. They usually stem from a sense of insecurity from wondering “do I have what it takes to succeed?” Apple is so

KEY QUOTES

“Companies tend to sell solutions to external problems, but customers buy solutions to internal problems.”

“People’s internal desire to resolve a frustration is a greater motivator than their desire to solve an external problem.”

successful because its simple interface addresses an internal frustration—people want to use technology but feel intimidated by it.

- *Philosophical.* This involves the “why” that goes beyond the story, e.g. “good should triumph over evil”, “everyone deserves to be loved”, “we ought to stand up to injustice”

 Businesses typically focus on solving external problems, when people buy things to solve internal problems (e.g. frustration and self-doubt). Ideally, they want a solution that concurrently solves all 3 levels of problems. Consider how you can position your solution as a tool for external/internal problems, as well as a way for customers to express themselves and stand for something bigger. For example:

TESLA MOTOR CARS	NESPRESSO HOME COFFEE MACHINES
Villain: Gas guzzling, inferior tech External: I need a car Internal: I want to be an early adopter of new technology. Philosophical: I should choose a car that’s environmentally-friendly.	Villain: Coffee machines that make bad coffee External: I want good coffee at home. Internal: I want to feel sophisticated. Philosophical: I shouldn’t have to be a barrister to make gourmet coffee at home.

3. The Guide



Customers want a guide, not another hero.

 At various points in our lives, we all encounter “guides” who give us a helping hand and shape our views, actions and lives. Likewise, every hero needs a guide.

- Heroes start out with self-doubts and problems they can’t solve on their own. They need a guide who has “been there, done that” and can point them in the right direction. Star Wars’ Luke Skywalker was guided by Yoda, while Hunger Games’ Katniss was guided by Haymitch.
- Don’t position your brand as the hero, or you’ll end up competing with your customers. Be the guide they’re looking for. If you focus on your customers’ success, your own success will follow.

 To establish yourself as a trustworthy guide, you must show 2 characteristics:

KEY QUOTES

“People are looking for a philosophy they can embody or a series of steps they can take to solve their problems.”

“Nearly every human being is looking for a guide (or guides) to help them win the day.”

“Always position your customer as the hero and your brand as the guide. Always.”

- Empathy. All human beings want to be seen, heard, and understood. Show you know your customers' pain and frustration with phrases like "We understand how it feels to ..." or "Nobody should have to go through this . . ." or "Like you, we find it frustrating when..." When your customers feel that you understand them and share something in common, they'll start to trust you.
- Authority. Demonstrate that you know what you're doing and can guide them to their desired destination. You can establish your competence (without bragging) using these 4 ways:
 - (i) Share a few succinct testimonials of the results that other heroes have achieved with you;
 - (ii) Present simple statistics e.g. the number of satisfied customers or the % growth in your clients' profits;
 - (iii) Include a few key awards you've won; and/or
 - (iv) Include logos of well-known businesses you've worked with (if you're in a B-to-B business).

4. The Plan



Customers will only trust a guide with a plan.



Once you establish yourself as a guide, you have a relationship with the customer. However, to part with their hard-earned money and make a purchase, your customers must be ready to commit.

- To win this trust and commitment, you must demonstrate that you have a clear plan to solve their problems.
- A good plan should (i) lay out how exactly to do business with you and/or (ii) remove the perceived risks that are holding your customers back.



Specifically, there are 2 types of plans you can present:

- A process plan lays out the steps needed to buy and/or use your product. A pre-purchase plan could look like this: fix an appointment → we'll customize a plan for you → we'll execute

KEY QUOTES

"The day we stop losing sleep over the success of our business and start losing sleep over the success of our customers is the day our business will start growing again."

"People trust those who understand them, and they trust brands that understand them too."

"The key to the success of any plan is to alleviate confusion for our customers."

"If process plans are about alleviating confusion, agreement plans are about alleviating fears."

the plan together. A post-purchase plan could involve these steps: download the app → input your expenses → manage your finances. Keep the process to 3-6 steps to minimize confusion.

- An agreement plan lists out the assurances to allay customers' fears of doing business with you. You're basically saying, "If you buy this, we'll do all that". List down all the concerns your customer may have, then develop a list of agreements to address them. Besides eliminating customers' perceived risks, the list can increase the perceived value of your solution and clarify your shared values. This plan doesn't have to be featured upfront (e.g. on the home page of your website), but can be presented on your walls, paper bags, FAQ pages etc.

 Name the plans in a way that conveys the value or benefits to your customers e.g. "easy installment plan" or "our quality guarantee".

5. Calls to Action



Customers won't take action unless they're challenged to do so.



People don't make major decisions unless they have a clear reason and are pushed to do so. You must call them to action.

- Never assume your customers can read your mind. You must explicitly ask them to buy, and must do so repeatedly. Your customers are flooded by thousands of commercial messages daily—unless you're loud and clear, they won't hear you.
- Don't worry about overselling. If you're truly confident of solving your customers' problems, you should have no qualms about prodding them to jump onboard. In fact, if you don't sell with conviction, you convey a lack of confidence in your solution.



There are 2 types of calls to action:

- Direct calls to action are simply direct purchase requests, e.g. "buy now", "book an appointment today" or "call for an instant quotation". The key is to repeat them in various formats on your website, signboards, emails etc. For example, you should have multiple "Buy-now" buttons on your website in different colors, sizes and fonts. Each call to action should lead to a sale or at least bring the customer closer to a purchase.

KEY QUOTES

"Bodies at rest tend to stay at rest, and so do customers. Heroes need to be challenged by outside forces."

"Most people think they're overselling when, in truth, their calls to action fall softer than a whisper."

"If you aren't asking people to place an order, they won't."

- Transitional calls to action: Even if someone isn't ready to buy yet, you can progressively deepen the relationship until they're ready. It's like dating—you won't give up just because someone isn't ready to marry you on the first date. You can share (i) free information (e.g. worksheets, webinars or videos that position you as a guide/expert in an area), (ii) testimonials that reinforce the story map in your potential customers' minds, and/or (iii) samples or free trials that let people experience your products. These help you to claim your niche/territory, develop a sense of reciprocity, and position yourself as a guide in customers' minds.

6. Avoid Failure



Everyone wants to avoid a tragic ending.



All human beings are only motivated by 2 things: to avoid pain (something bad) or to seek pleasure (something good). This element is about defining what's at stake so your potential customers feel motivated to take action to avoid failure or disaster.

- We follow a story only because there's something at stake. We want to know if the hero will save the world from disaster or win the girl of his dreams. Likewise, we must show our potential customers the costs of not using our products or services.
- There are many opportunities to reinforce what's at stake, e.g. in your website messages, through your blog titles or e-mail content. The key is to create a sense of urgency without overdoing it.



There are 2 types of failures you can highlight:

- Potential loss. Human beings are fundamentally loss-averse, i.e. we don't want to lose what we have/own. Help potential customers realize that (i) they're at risk (e.g. 1 out of 4 people get cancer) and (ii) they should take action to reduce their vulnerability. Then specify the call to action and challenge them to take action *now*.
- Bad outcomes. Define the negative outcomes you're helping your customers to prevent, e.g. losing money, getting sick, being infested by pests.

KEY QUOTES

"A story lives and dies based on the question: Will the hero succeed or will they fail?"

"Too much and your customers will resist you, too little and they won't know why your products even matter."

"Remember, if there are no stakes, there is no story."

Here are a couple of examples of bad outcomes:

USED CARS	SUMMER CAMP FOR KIDS
Being ripped off by a used-car salesman Being stuck with a lemon Feeling foolish/taken advantage of	A long, boring summer Restless kids running around the house Regret wasting the summer

7. Attain Success



Tell people how you can improve their lives. Don't assume they know.

 This is where you give customers the happy ending to their story. Paint a clear, aspirational picture of where you'll bring them, i.e. what their life could look like if they use your products or services.

- Be specific. For example, J.F. Kennedy painted a simple but powerful vision: "We're going to put a man on the moon."
- You can use this "Before-and-After exercise" by Ryan Deiss to crystallize how your brand will change customers' lives.

	Before your Brand	After your Brand
What do they have?		
What are they feeling?		
What's their average day like?		
What's their status?		

* Adapted from Ryan Deiss

 There're 3 key ways to end the story powerfully for your customers.

- Gaining power or status, e.g. helping your customers to become more respected, admired or attractive. Perceived status could come from access to privileges, getting something scarce, having a premium status (e.g. being a Diamond member or Star Donor), or being associated with other premium brands.
- Becoming whole with something extrinsic, e.g. finding their other half, having tools that let them do superhuman work, having the time and money to do everything they want.
- Becoming whole with something intrinsic, e.g. feeling inner peace and self-acceptance when they achieve their full potential or become who they're meant to be. You could provide this happy ending by helping your customers to accomplish inspirational

KEY QUOTES

"Everybody wants to be taken somewhere. If we don't tell people where we're taking them, they'll engage another brand."

feats, accept who they are, or become a part of a wider movement/purpose.

 In short, the 3 key elements above can help people to resolve their external, internal, and philosophical problems. By presenting this vision clearly as a core part of your brand promise, you create closure to the story and convince your customers to follow you.

Going Beyond the 7 Elements: Personal Transformation



 Once you’ve completed your BrandScript, you can now address the strongest motivator for action: the human desire for transformation. All of us want to become a better version of who we are, e.g. to be fitter, wiser, more attractive, more respected etc.

- In any story, the hero will undergo change and development. They develop new skills, find inner strengths, build their character and eventually prevail.
- Ask yourself: Who do your customers aspire to become? How would they want others to describe them? How can your brand help them to become that person? Define the aspirational identity behind your brand, use it in all your communications and as a guide for your business. For example:

PET FOOD BRAND	SHAMPOO BRAND
From: Passive dog owner To: Every dog’s hero	From: Anxious and dull To: Carefree and radiant

 Great brands don’t just sell a product or service; they are fanatical about their customers’ success and transformation. As you help your customers to solve their problems and become the heroes they aspire to be, you’re not just growing a business; you’re also changing lives.

Implement your StoryBrand



Once you’ve created your BrandScript, you can apply it in several steps.

Improve your website



 Your website leaves a critical first impression, much like a first date. Make sure it passes the grunt test and has these 5 elements:

KEY QUOTES

“Everybody wants to be somebody different, somebody better, or, perhaps, somebody who simply becomes more self-accepting.”

“Brands that participate in the identity transformation of their customers create passionate brand evangelists.”

“Participating in your customer’s transformation can give new life and meaning to your business.”

“Let’s do more than help our heroes win; let’s help them transform.”

“A great digital presence starts with a clear and effective website.”

- A clear offer “above the fold”. The top part of your website (that’s visible without scrolling) must clearly convey what you offer, e.g. “We will make you a golf pro” or “We help you design beautiful websites.” The key message (text and image) above the fold must (i) promise an aspirational identity, (ii) promise to solve a problem (e.g. stop hair loss, clear choked drains), and/or (iii) specify what you do (e.g. “we walk your dogs”).
- Explicit calls to action, e.g. your “register today” or “buy now” buttons. Your customer typically reads your website in a Z-shape, so you should minimally have call-to-action buttons on the top-right, in the middle of the screen just above the fold, and later as people scroll down. Make the buttons obvious, repeat your message and state the transitional actions clearly.
- Success-related images of happy, satisfied customers.
- Snapshot of key revenue streams. If you have multiple products or revenue streams, start with an overarching message, then break down the specific products/divisions later so people can choose the right options.
- Few words. People scan through websites; they don’t read them. Wherever possible, use images, 3-4 bullet points or short soundbites. Minimize full sentences and avoid paragraphs.



Stick to the BrandScript. You can vary the choice of words but don’t add new ideas outside the script or you’ll create noise.

Transform your Organization



- Use the BrandScript to bring internal clarity and create employee engagement. In most organizations, there’s nothing holding together the mission statement, strategy, operations, guidelines and metrics. As a result, employees feel overwhelmed and confused by the sheer amount of information and noise.
- A story can bring your mission to life and help people to understand how the various parts of your business all fit into a grand adventure.
 - In your company story, your team members are the heroes and your leaders are the guides. A new recruit becomes a part of

KEY QUOTES

“The stuff you share on a first date should be short, enticing, and exclusively customer-centric.”

“The fewer words you use, the more likely it is that people will read them.”

“With a StoryBrand-inspired narrative, ordinary jobs become extraordinary adventures.”

“A true mission isn’t a statement; it’s a way of living and being.”

this story, gets transformed by the company and is excited to see how the story unfolds with the various stakeholders.

- Your ultimate goal is to align the company story and customer story. When your company is on-mission, every staff becomes an ambassador. They know the company story and can spread the message using consistent, compelling soundbites.

Grow your Business



By now, you have a clear, effective message both internally and externally. You're ready to grow your business rapidly with 5 remaining steps:

- Develop a One-liner that integrates the Character, the Problem, the Plan, and the Success, e.g. "We provide busy executives and entrepreneurs with easy-to-digest summaries of top business and personal development books so they're equipped to move ahead with confidence and purpose". This summarizes your entire business, and should be used by all your team-members and in all your communications (e.g. website, email, name cards etc.).
- Create a lead generator (e.g. pdf, video series) and collect email addresses, with the aim to create value for your customers and position yourself as an authority in your niche.
- Build an automated e-mail drip campaign. Send your potential customers value-adding emails regularly, e.g. talk about a problem, share a plan to solve it, describe how life looks like with the problem solved, and include a call to action.
- Share transformation stories. Collect and share customer testimonials (about the problems and frustrations they faced, how your product helped them and what life looks like now).
- Create a referral-generation system. Convert happy customers into brand ambassadors. Define your ideal customers, give your existing customers a good reason to spread the word (e.g. offer a reward) and automate the process.

KEY QUOTES

"Brief, narrative ideas shared from inspired team members spread faster than muddled, confusing explanations shared by bored, disengaged employees."